



Out of runs: Suryakumar Yadav endured a lean Asia Cup with the bat, managing only 72 runs in seven innings despite an unbeaten 47 against Pakistan earlier in the competition. AFP



Spinning a web: Kuldeep Yadav has now claimed 36 wickets across ODI and T20 Asia Cups — the most by any bowler, surpassing Lasith Malinga's 33. Seventeen came in this edition's T20s, the joint-most in the tournament's history. AP

certain conditions and oppositions may warrant the inclusion of a second full-time seamer to accompany Bumrah. The team management shouldn't be averse to sacrificing batting depth in exchange for a more well-rounded and attacking bowling combination. For this team, a batter or an all-rounder at No. 8 has been more about mental assurance than substantive impact. Given India's strong batting, the No. 8 batter has faced fewer than three balls per innings on average since 2024.

An imperfect Indian team was still too good, and the mood music surrounding the tournament almost fatalistically veered towards determining 'Asia's second-best team'. It was a tag that was passed around over the course of three weeks, from Afghanistan to Sri Lanka and Bangladesh, before a mercurial Pakistan reached the final.

They all attempted to shape themselves in the image of India's belligerence, with varying degrees of success. Pakistan often failed to maintain a bright start after 10 overs, and Bangladesh's batters took aggressive batting to an illogical extreme when they bungled a 136-run chase against Salman Agha's men. Sri Lanka's tryst with collapses continued, and Afghanistan lacked the resources to pursue high-risk cricket. For India, it was a stepping stone towards bigger honours.



Top Wicket-Takers

Kuldeep Yadav (India) — 17 wickets in 7 matches | Ave: 9.29
Shaheen Shah Afridi (Pakistan) — 10 wickets in 7 matches | Ave: 16.40
Junaid Siddique (UAE) — 9 wickets in 3 matches | Ave: 6.33
Mustafizur Rahman (Bangladesh) — 9 wickets in 6 matches | Ave: 19.00
Haris Rauf (Pakistan) — 9 wickets in 5 matches | Ave: 18.33